

Lagenorhynchus obliquidens

Pacific white-sided dolphin



Length 7–8¼ ft (2.1–2.5 m)
Weight About 440 lb (200 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern

Location North Pacific



Distinguished by its tapering head, coloration, and tall dorsal fin, this dolphin often rides ship bow waves in the North Pacific. It has a dark back, a gray-white belly, and a lower flank patch from the beak to level with the dorsal fin.

A pale stripe from the tail base extends forward to level with the dorsal fin, then it may fork, arching over the shoulder region to near the eye. This dolphin eats a variety of fish and squid, using 23–36 pairs of small teeth in both the upper and lower jaws. It forms fast-changing schools numbering tens to thousands, and often associates with other dolphins and whales. After a gestation period of 10–12 months, the female gives birth to a single calf, which is 3 ft (90 cm) long. This dolphin makes up a sizable part of the catch in some fishing industries of the northwest Pacific Ocean.

Lagenorhynchus albirostris

White-beaked dolphin



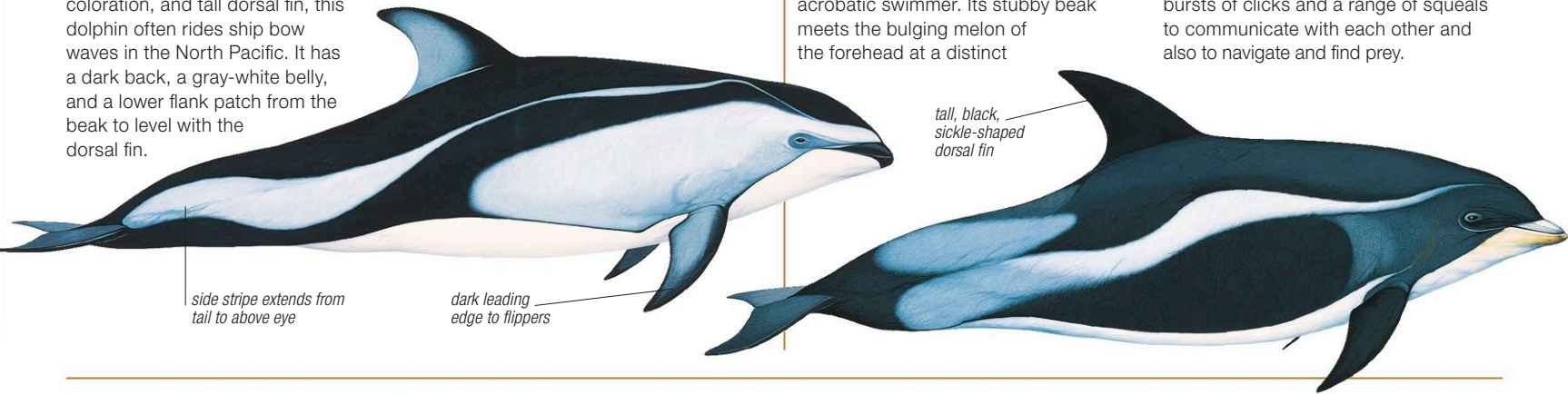
Length 7¾–10 ft (2.4–3.1 m)
Weight 395–770 lb (180–350 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern

Location North Atlantic



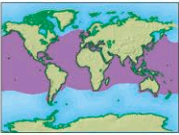
This large, stocky dolphin is an acrobatic swimmer. Its stubby beak meets the bulging melon of the forehead at a distinct

angle. Coloration is mainly dark gray or black with variable gray or white patches extending along the upper and lower flanks; the underside, including the beak, tends to be white. It has 22–28 pairs of robust, cone-shaped teeth in both upper and lower jaws, for feeding on open-water shoaling fish such as herring, although sea bed-dwelling flatfish and squid are also taken. The single calf, 3½–4 ft (110–120 cm) long, is born, like many other dolphins, in summer. White-beaked dolphins congregate in rapidly changing schools numbering from 5 to more than 1,000. They produce machine-gun-like bursts of clicks and a range of squeals to communicate with each other and also to navigate and find prey.



Grampus griseus

Risso's dolphin



Length 12½–13 ft (3.8–4.1 m)
Weight 880–1,102 lb (400–500 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern

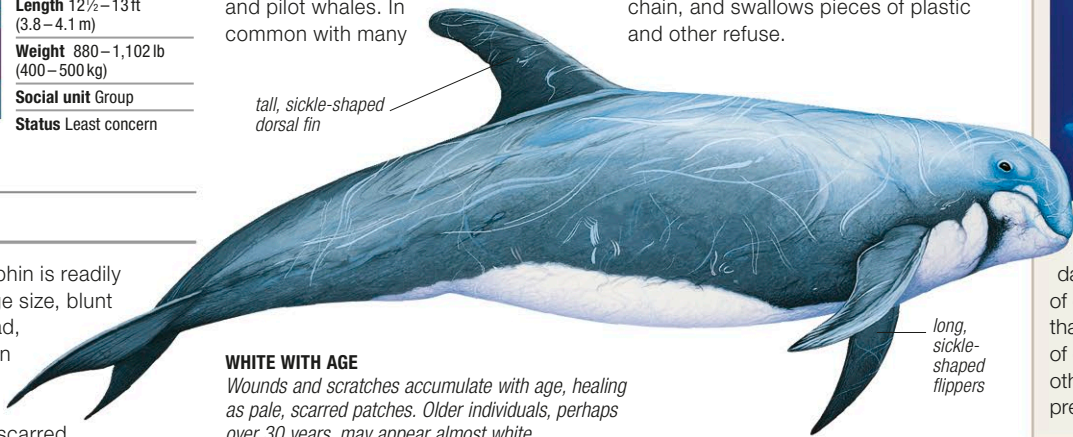
Location Pacific, Atlantic, Mediterranean, Indian Ocean



This distinctive dolphin is readily identified by its large size, blunt and “beakless” head, central crease down the bulging melon, tall dorsal fin, and overall gray, white-scarred

coloration. It forms schools of 10–50, but these may aggregate into groups of several hundreds mixed with other cetaceans, especially smaller dolphins and pilot whales. In common with many

other dolphins, Risso's dolphin suffers from human activities. It is asphyxiated in fishing nets, accumulates pollutants in the body through the food chain, and swallows pieces of plastic and other refuse.



WHITE WITH AGE
Wounds and scratches accumulate with age, healing as pale, scarred patches. Older individuals, perhaps over 30 years, may appear almost white.

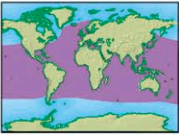
COMMUNICATION



Risso's dolphins dive deeply and eat mainly squid. Water darkens with depth, so sounds of echolocation are more important than sight for locating prey. Parties of dolphins may monitor each other's clicks and echoes, to find prey more efficiently.

Tursiops truncatus

Bottlenose dolphin



Length 6¼–13 ft (1.9–4 m)
Weight 300–1,400 lb (136–635 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

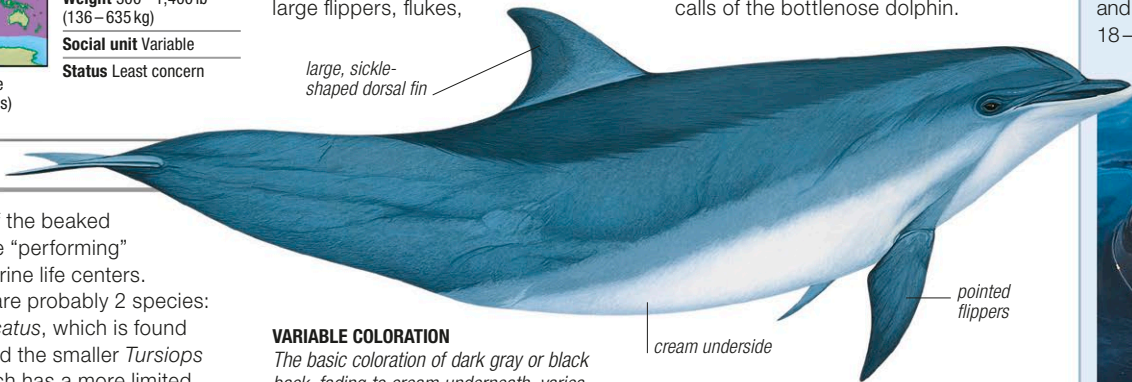
Location Worldwide (except polar regions)



This largest of the beaked dolphins is the “performing” species of marine life centers. In fact, there are probably 2 species: *Tursiops truncatus*, which is found worldwide, and the smaller *Tursiops aduncus*, which has a more limited range off the coast of India and in the

West Pacific. There may even be more species, considering the wide variation across regions and habitats. Around tropical coasts, the bottlenose dolphin is an average of 6½ ft (2 m) long, and has relatively large flippers, flukes,

and dorsal fin. In colder, open oceans they are almost twice as long, with proportionately smaller extremities. Social groupings and feeding methods are similarly varied over its range, as are the leaps, water-slaps, sounds, and calls of the bottlenose dolphin.



VARIABLE COLORATION
The basic coloration of dark gray or black back, fading to cream underneath, varies in hue and pattern between individuals.

ADAPTABILITY

The bottlenose dolphin, named for its short and robust beak, is an adaptable, successful generalist. It eats many kinds of fish, mollusks, and crustaceans, which it grips with 18–27 pairs of small, conical teeth in both jaws.

